



CAMBRIDGE
International Education

Syllabus

Cambridge IGCSE™ Drama 0411

Use this syllabus for exams in 2028.
Exams are available in the June and November series.



Version 0.2

For the purposes of screen readers, any mention in this document of Cambridge IGCSE refers to Cambridge International General Certificate of Secondary Education.

Cambridge
Pathway

Why choose Cambridge?

We work with schools worldwide to build an education that shapes knowledge, understanding and skills. Together, we give learners the confidence they need to thrive and make a positive impact in a changing world.

As part of the University of Cambridge, we offer a globally trusted and flexible framework for education from age 3 to 19, informed by research, experience, and listening to educators.

With recognised qualifications, high-quality resources, comprehensive support and valuable insights, we help schools prepare every student for the opportunities and challenges ahead.

Qualifications that are recognised and valued worldwide

From the world's top-ranked universities to local higher education institutions, Cambridge qualifications open doors to a world of opportunities.

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With over 160 years of experience in delivering fair, valid and reliable assessments to students worldwide, we offer a global, recognised performance standard for international education.

Your path, your way

Schools can adapt our curriculum, high-quality teaching and learning resources and flexible assessments to their local context. Our aligned offer helps Cambridge schools support every learner to reach their potential and thrive.

Learning with lasting impact

Cambridge learners build subject knowledge and conceptual understanding, and develop a broad range of skills, learning habits and attributes to help make them ready for the world.

Improving learning outcomes through data-led insight and action

Our trusted baseline and diagnostic assessments, together with our insights and evaluation service, help schools turn data into knowledge and actionable insights, to inform teaching decisions and improve learner outcomes.

Bringing together a community of experts

We bring together the collective knowledge of experts and our diverse community of educators worldwide, supporting them to learn from one another and share ideas and information.

Tackling the climate crisis together

We believe that education is key to tackling the climate crisis. Together with Cambridge schools, we can empower young people with the skills and knowledge to take action on climate change, helping them be ready for the world.

School feedback: 'We think the Cambridge curriculum is superb preparation for university.'

Feedback from: Christoph Guttentag, Dean of Undergraduate Admissions, Duke University, USA

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Important: Changes to this syllabus



The latest syllabus is version 1, published September 2025. There are no significant changes which affect teaching.

Any textbooks endorsed to support the syllabus for examination from 2022 are still suitable for use with this syllabus.

1 Why choose this syllabus?

Key benefits

Cambridge IGCSE is the world's most popular international qualification for 14 to 16 year olds, although it can be taken by students at any age. Taught by over 5000 schools in 150 countries, it is tried, tested and trusted.

Students can choose from 70 subjects in any combination, including 30 languages.

Our programmes promote a thorough knowledge and understanding of a subject and help to develop the skills learners need for their next steps in education or employment.

Cambridge IGCSE Drama provides opportunities for learners to develop practical skills in performance, both as an individual and within a group. Learners will understand the artistic choices made by actors, directors and designers in presenting performances for an audience. They will also learn about theatrical styles and genres. Learners will explore how to develop their own ideas in creating original drama.

Our approach in Cambridge IGCSE Drama encourages learners to be:

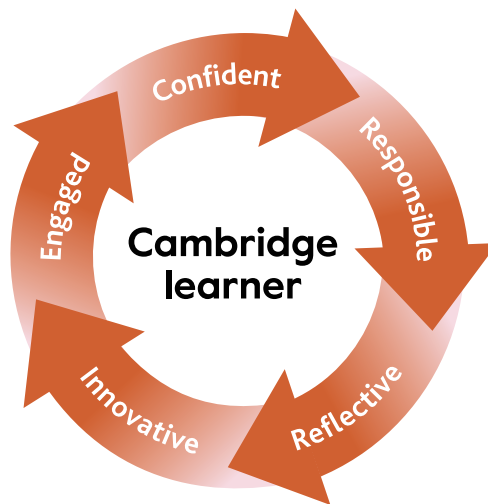
confident, developing practical skills to deliver dramatic performance for an audience

responsible, developing shared responsibility working with others and understanding the power of drama to engage, influence and persuade

reflective, engaging with performance processes, and using them to inform future practice

innovative, creating original dramatic work and formulating imaginative responses to existing repertoire

engaged, developing their enjoyment of drama to support their practical, intellectual and artistic growth.



School feedback: 'The strength of Cambridge IGCSE qualifications is internationally recognised and has provided an international pathway for our students to continue their studies around the world.'

Feedback from: Gary Tan, Head of Schools and CEO, Raffles Group of Schools, Indonesia

Qualifications that are recognised and valued worldwide

Cambridge qualifications prepare and equip learners with the skills they need to thrive at university and beyond. The world's best higher education institutions recognise our qualifications and value the critical thinking skills, independent research abilities and deep subject knowledge that Cambridge learners bring.

We continually work with universities and colleges in every part of the world to ensure that they understand and accept our qualifications. Cambridge IGCSE provides a springboard to the Cambridge Advanced stage, as well as other post-16 routes. The combination of knowledge and skills in Cambridge IGCSE Drama gives learners a solid foundation for further study. Candidates who achieve grades A* to C are well prepared to follow a wide range of courses including Cambridge International AS & A Level Drama (9482).

Many universities require a combination of Cambridge International AS & A Levels and Cambridge IGCSEs or equivalent to meet their entry requirements.

UK ENIC, the national agency in the UK for the recognition and comparison of international qualifications and skills, has carried out an independent benchmarking study of Cambridge IGCSE and found it to be comparable to the standard of the GCSE in the UK. This means students can be confident that their Cambridge IGCSE qualifications are accepted as equivalent to UK GCSEs by leading universities worldwide.

Learn more at www.cambridgeinternational.org/recognition

School feedback: 'Cambridge IGCSE is one of the most sought-after and recognised qualifications in the world. It is very popular in Egypt because it provides the perfect preparation for success at advanced level programmes.'

Feedback from: Managing Director of British School of Egypt BSE

Supporting teachers

We believe education works best when teaching and learning are closely aligned to the curriculum, resources and assessment. Our high-quality teaching support helps to maximise teaching time and enables teachers to engage learners of all backgrounds and abilities.

We aim to provide the following support for each Cambridge qualification:

- Syllabus
- Specimen question papers and mark schemes
- Specimen paper answers
- Schemes of Work
- Example candidate responses
- Past papers and mark schemes
- Principal examiner reports for teachers

These resources are available on the School Support Hub at www.cambridgeinternational.org/support, our secure online site for Cambridge teachers. Your exams officer can provide you with a login.

Additional teaching & learning resources are also available for many syllabuses and vary according to the nature of the subject and the structure of the assessment of each syllabus. These can include ready-built lesson materials, digital resources and multimedia for the classroom and homework, guidance on assessment and much more. Beyond the resources available on the Schools Support Hub, a wide range of endorsed textbooks and associated teaching and learning support are available from Cambridge at www.cambridge.org/education and from other publishers. Resources vary according to the nature of the subject and the structure of the assessment of each syllabus.

You can also contact our global Cambridge community or talk to a senior examiner on our discussion forums.

Sign up for email notifications about changes to syllabuses, including new and revised products and services, at www.cambridgeinternational.org/syllabusupdates

Professional development

Find the next step on your professional development journey.

- **Introduction courses** – An introduction to Cambridge programmes and qualifications. For teachers who are new to Cambridge programmes or new to a specific syllabus.
- **Focus on Teaching courses** – These are for teachers who want to explore a specific area of teaching and learning within a syllabus or programme.
- **Focus on Assessment courses** – These are for teachers who want to understand the assessment of a syllabus in greater depth.
- **Marking workshops** – These workshops help you become more familiar with what examiners are looking for, and provide an opportunity to raise questions and share your experiences of the syllabus.
- **Enrichment Professional Development** – Transform your approach to teaching with our Enrichment workshops. Each workshop focuses on a specific area of teaching and learning practice.
- **Cambridge Professional Development Qualifications (PDQs)** – Practice-based programmes that transform professional learning for practicing teachers. Available at Certificate and Diploma level.

For more information visit www.cambridgeinternational.org/support-and-training-for-schools

Supporting exams officers

We provide comprehensive support and guidance for all Cambridge exams officers.
Find out more at: www.cambridgeinternational.org/eoguide



2 Syllabus overview

Aims

The aims describe the purposes of a course based on this syllabus.

Students following a course based on this syllabus will develop:

- an interest in and enjoyment of drama and theatre
- an understanding of the dramatic process of moving from script to performance
- skills in devising original drama
- practical performance skills as individuals and within a group
- an understanding of, and engagement with, the role of actor, director and designer in creating a piece of drama
- an understanding of how performers communicate with an audience.

Cambridge IGCSE Drama aims to encourage progression to AS Level or A Level study in drama.



We are an education organisation and politically neutral. The contents of this syllabus, examination papers and associated materials do not endorse any political view. We endeavour to treat all aspects of the exam process neutrally.

Content overview

Learners develop an understanding and enjoyment of drama through practical and theoretical study.

Candidates will study:

- the elements of practical drama
- how to work with extracts from published plays as an actor, director and designer
- how to devise, develop and structure their own original dramatic material from stimuli such as short titles, poems, pictures, songs, historical events and stories
- how to evaluate their contribution to the devising process and the success of the final piece
- how to use staging and design as part of a dramatic performance
- individual and group performance skills and how they are applied to create character and communicate meaning to an audience.

Assessment overview

All candidates take two components. Candidates will be eligible for grades A* to G.

All candidates take:	and:
Paper 1 2 hours 30 minutes Written examination 40% 80 marks Candidates answer: • all questions in Section A • two questions in Section B (one compulsory question and one question from a choice of two) • both questions in Section C. Externally assessed	Component 2 Coursework 60% 120 marks Candidates submit three pieces of practical work: • individual performance based on an extract from a play • group performance based on an extract from a play • group performance based on an original devised piece. Internally assessed and externally moderated

Information on availability is in the **Before you start** section.

Check the samples database at www.cambridgeinternational.org/samples for submission information, forms and deadlines for Component 2.

The pre-release material for Paper 1 is made available to centres before the exam. It is also reproduced in the question paper. Candidates must not bring any prepared materials into the exam.

Teachers should check the Cambridge website for the relevant year of assessment for information on when and where the pre-release materials will be available. Information on pre-release materials can be found here: www.cambridgeinternational.org/prerelease

Assessment objectives

The assessment objectives (AOs) are:

AO1 Knowledge and understanding of repertoire

Candidates demonstrate their knowledge and understanding of the process of moving from script to performance, and can justify artistic choices as actor, director or designer.

AO2 Devising original drama

Candidates demonstrate their ability to devise and evaluate their own original pieces of drama.

AO3 Performance skills

Candidates demonstrate their performance skills and their ability to communicate effectively with an audience.

Weighting for assessment objectives

The approximate weightings allocated to each of the assessment objectives (AOs) are summarised below.

Assessment objectives as a percentage of the qualification

Assessment objective	Weighting in IGCSE %
AO1 Knowledge and understanding of repertoire	40
AO2 Devising original drama	30
AO3 Performance skills	30
Total	100

Assessment objectives as a percentage of each component

Assessment objective	Weighting in components %	
	Paper 1	Component 2
AO1 Knowledge and understanding of repertoire	70	25
AO2 Devising original drama	30	25
AO3 Performance skills	0	50
Total	100	100

3 Subject content

Drama is a practical subject. Learners should pursue a skills-driven course that allows them to develop their ability to perform effectively in a dramatic production for the stage.

This syllabus gives you the flexibility to design a course that will interest, challenge and engage your learners. Where appropriate you are responsible for selecting resources and examples, topics and subject contexts to support your learners' study. These should be appropriate for the learners' age, cultural background and learning context as well as complying with your school policies and local legal requirements.

Both group and individual acting skills will be developed using two fundamental approaches, which together form the core of this syllabus:

- the process of moving from script to performance using extracts from published plays
- the process of devising and performing original drama from a stimulus.

From script to performance and Devising from a stimulus

There are several overlaps between moving from script to performance using published plays and devising an original drama from a stimulus. In both processes, learners should take an integrated approach to the creation and staging of dramatic performance. This means that teachers and learners should consider the contribution of actors, directors and designers to the interpretation and shaping of dramatic material.

The content listed under the headings 'Elements of practical drama', 'Performance skills' and 'Staging and design' are fundamental to **both** moving from script to performance and devising original drama. Content specific to each approach is provided under the headings 'From script to performance' and 'Devising original drama from a stimulus'.

From script to performance and Devising from a stimulus

Elements of practical drama

Candidates should be able to demonstrate knowledge and understanding of:

- key practical drama concepts such as:
 - structure and plot
 - characterisation and role
 - dialogue
 - physicality
 - pacing
 - contrast and dynamics
 - tension
 - spatial awareness and proxemics
- how actors, directors and designers respond to different styles and genres of drama
- how choices made by actors, directors and designers can affect performances and audience responses
- how actors, directors and designers work within constraints, such as available resources and performance space
- how to use appropriate performance, technical and design vocabulary when writing about drama
- how to communicate with an audience

continued

From script to performance and Devising from a stimulus continued

Elements of practical drama continued

Candidates should be able to:

- reflect on and evaluate the effectiveness of their own artistic choices as actor, director or designer
- write critically about the process of bringing a piece of drama to a finished performance
- analyse and evaluate their own performance including their contribution to the group

Performance skills

Candidates should be able to understand and demonstrate:

- a range of vocal and physical performance techniques
- effective use of performance space
- creation of role through realisation of character
- the ability to sustain role(s) throughout a performance
- the use of pacing, tension and emotional intensity in performance
- how to communicate with the audience through engaging performance
- skills in individual/solo performance
- skills in working with others in group performance
- how to improve their own performance through rehearsal and interaction

Staging and design

Learners should be aware of staging and design aspects of both scripted and devised performances. Learners should be able to discuss how design elements are integral to a dramatic production and enhance its effectiveness. Learners do **not** need specialist knowledge or access to specialist equipment. The examples listed here are suggested rather than prescribed ways in which candidates can demonstrate knowledge and understanding. These examples are **not** exhaustive.

Candidates should be aware of:

- key design areas and their contribution to a dramatic performance:
 - **costume**, e.g. how costume design can communicate period, style, character, status
 - **set**, e.g. how set design can help communicate a director's dramatic ideas
 - **props**, e.g. how stage properties can be a part of a set design and how the use of personal props can help actors develop their character
 - **lighting**, e.g. how lighting can create mood and atmosphere and contribute to transitions
 - **sound**, e.g. how sound can be used to create spot or atmospheric effects
 - **stage space**, e.g. how the use of the performance space and staging can affect an audience's reaction to a performance

From script to performance

The process of moving from script to performance refers to the theoretical and practical journey undertaken by actors, directors and designers from the initial read-through of a play script to the final performance. This might include discussion of dramatic intention and how it may be achieved, practical exploration and evaluation of ideas, and application of appropriate performance skills. This process encourages a holistic approach of learning by doing where learning comes from the activity of delivering a performance. Learners should focus on the script as a piece of drama rather than a piece of literature.

In addition to the content listed under the headings 'Elements of practical drama', 'Performance skills' and 'Staging and design', candidates must also study the content under the heading 'Working with published plays'.

Working with published plays

Candidates should be able to:

- demonstrate skills in performing an extract from a published play
- understand how to bring the printed script alive on the stage, including the speaking of words and lines, the use of pause or delay, tone, character interaction, movement, timing, business, action, etc.
- understand the relationship between spoken word, facial expression, gesture and posture
- understand approaches to interpreting a published play from a director's viewpoint
- demonstrate the ability to write about the process of bringing the script to life
- demonstrate the ability to write about the contribution of design elements to final performance

Devising original drama from a stimulus

The devising process consists of the interpretation of a stimulus from which learners develop a scenario and its characters within a dramatic structure. A key part of the process requires learners to reflect on and evaluate their contribution to the devised piece, as well as evaluate the effect of the piece on the audience.

In this syllabus, the most important characteristics of a devised dramatic performance are:

- it grows out of the exploration of a stimulus
- performers collaborate in its creation
- it is an original piece of work, which may make use of an appropriate style or genre of drama.

In addition to the content listed under the headings 'Elements of practical drama', 'Performance skills' and 'Staging and design', candidates must also study the content under the headings 'Developing dramatic material through the devising process' and 'Working with stimuli in the devising process'.

Developing dramatic material through the devising process

Candidates should be able to:

- understand how original drama may be created
- demonstrate understanding of how to structure an original dramatic piece, including:
 - establishing a clear dramatic intention
 - creating a scenario and structure that will enable the dramatic intention to be realised
 - creating credible characters
 - using dialogue, pacing and inflections of spoken English
 - exploring the relationship between spoken word, facial gesture and bodily posture
 - using physical space effectively
 - taking or giving direction where appropriate
 - exploring how design elements can contribute to the effectiveness of the piece
- evaluate the devising process and write about it

Working with stimuli in the devising process

Candidates should be able to:

- demonstrate skills in creating performance from a dramatic stimulus
- analyse and evaluate their contribution to the devised piece
- analyse and evaluate the effect of the devised piece on the audience
- understand the devising and rehearsal processes, and be able to write about them

Examples of possible stimuli are:

- dramatic styles or genres:
 - children's drama
 - melodrama
 - commedia dell'Arte
 - documentary theatre
 - forum theatre (Boal)
 - folk theatre
- socio-historical stimuli:
 - an issue of conscience
 - a personal issue
 - an environmental issue
- other options:
 - a piece of music or song
 - a poem
 - a sculpture or image
 - a historical figure
 - a traditional story

Dramatic and theatrical terms

Learners should become familiar with the list of terms below during their study of Cambridge IGCSE Drama. Understanding these terms will help learners write about drama and participate more effectively in their practical work.

The list of terms is **not** exhaustive. Teachers are advised to consult the *Cambridge IGCSE Drama (0411) Glossary of dramatic and theatrical terms*, published on the School Support Hub at www.cambridgeinternational.org/support. The glossary provides definitions for a wide range of terms including technical vocabulary. The glossary is designed to support teaching and learning but is not prescriptive.

Core drama terms

Action	Mood/atmosphere
Chorus	Moment
Comedy/tragedy	Pace/rhythm/tempo
Conflict/suspense/tension	Plot/storyline
Contrast	Rehearsal process
Devised drama (as intended by this syllabus*)	Script
Devising process (as intended by this syllabus*)	Status
Dialogue	Structure
Ensemble	Theme
Exposition, climax and resolution	Theatre
Genre/style (of plays and performance)	Transition
Improvisation	

*see 'Devising original drama from a stimulus' on page 13

Spatial and staging terms

Acting area	Levels
Apron stage	Props
Arena stage	Proscenium (arch)
Auditorium (and audience configuration)	Scene
Blocking	Scenery
Design elements (lighting, sound, set, props, costume)	Set/setting
Downstage/upstage	Staging
End on staging	Theatre-in-the-round
Fourth wall	Thrust stage
	Traverse staging

Performance terms

Articulation	Motivation
Character and role	Movement and spatial awareness (proxemics)
Focus	Non-verbal expression
Gesture	Physicality
Inflection	Pitch, pause, pace
Interaction	Posture
Language (including tone, accent, dialect)	Status
Mime	Vocal expression and projection

Key personnel

Actor
 Designer (set, costume, props, lighting, sound)
 Director

Faculty feedback: ‘Understanding how and why our climate is changing and providing the knowledge and skills to explore the challenges plays a key role in every student’s education.’

Feedback from: Dr Amy Munro-Faure, Head of Education and Student Engagement of Cambridge Zero

4 Details of the assessment

This syllabus has two compulsory components:

- Paper 1 – Written examination
- Component 2 – Coursework.

Paper 1 has pre-release material.

Paper 1 – Pre-release material

The pre-release material for Paper 1 Written examination is available to centres before the exam. It is also reproduced with the question paper. Candidates must not bring any prepared material into the examinations.

Teachers should check the *Cambridge Handbook* for the relevant year of assessment for information on when the pre-release material will be available at www.cambridgeinternational.org/eoguide

The pre-release material will be available from the School Support Hub at www.cambridgeinternational.org/support. You will need access to the School Support Hub, our secure online site. This site is password protected. Please contact your school coordinator for instructions on how to access the School Support Hub.

It is the centre's responsibility to download the pre-release material and to provide learners with a printed copy for use during the course. Candidates may annotate this copy during the course but they may not take it into the examination with them. A clean printed copy will be provided by Cambridge International for the examination.

You must make sure you download the correct version of the pre-release material for your administrative zone. There are three administrative zones for this qualification. Each administrative zone has a unique question paper for Paper 1 (called a variant) with associated pre-release material. Each variant of the pre-release material contains different play extracts. The questions in Sections A and B of each variant of Paper 1 will be based on the extracts from the associated pre-release material.

If you are unsure which administrative zone your school is in, please check the Cambridge Exams Officers' guide on our website www.cambridgeinternational.org/eoguide

Paper 1 – Written examination

Written paper, 2 hours 30 minutes, 80 marks

This written examination has three sections. Candidates are advised to divide their time equally between each section.

	Focus of questions	Question type	Marks
Section A	An extract from a published play. Candidates should have studied the extract and explored it as practical theatre, investigating performing and staging opportunities. The extract is supplied in the pre-release material where it is identified as Extract 1.	Up to eight short-answer and extended-response questions. Marks per question range from 2 to 10. Candidates answer all questions	30
Section B	An extract from a different published play. Candidates should have studied the extract and explored it as practical theatre, investigating performing and staging opportunities. The extract is supplied in the pre-release material where it is identified as Extract 2.	Candidates answer two extended-response questions. One compulsory question (10 marks) and one question from a choice of two (15 marks).	25
Section C	A devised piece that candidates have developed and performed to an audience. The pre-release material is not required for the devised piece – teachers choose the stimulus.	Two extended-response questions. Candidates answer both questions (one is worth 10 marks, the other 15 marks).	25

Please note that all written responses must be presented in English.

Paper 1 – Sections A and B

The questions in Sections A and B relate to the pre-release material. The pre-release material must be downloaded from the School Support Hub. You must use the correct pre-release material for your administrative zone. You must **not** use the specimen pre-release material.

The pre-release material consists of **two** extracts, one from each of two published plays. Extracts will be selected from plays representing a range of genres, styles, countries, cultures and periods. All extracts will be in English and may include work in translation. Each extract will be of sufficient length and substance to enable candidates to demonstrate their understanding of practical approaches to performance as actor, director or designer. Extract 1 will be assessed in Section A and Extract 2 in Section B.

Candidates will be assessed on AO1 Knowledge and understanding of repertoire. The questions will assume that candidates have explored both extracts equally, taking a practical, rehearsal-based approach that allows them to consider the plays in performance. Candidates will be expected to have familiarity with a range of practical skills and approaches used by actors, directors and designers in interpreting specific sections of the extract as a whole. Candidates will be expected to have an overview of each extract and an understanding of its general context. Candidates will **not** be required to show familiarity with the complete play from which each extract is taken.

Paper 1 – Section C

The questions in Section C relate to an original piece of drama devised by the candidate as part of a group. The stimulus for this piece of drama is chosen by the teacher, so that it can be locally relevant and engaging for the candidates. Guidance on selecting an appropriate stimulus is provided on page 22. The devised piece that candidates choose to write about should be one that they have prepared to the same standard as the devised pieces they prepare for Component 2. For this reason, candidates may choose to answer the questions in Section C of Paper 1 on the same devised piece that they submit for assessment in Component 2, or another devised piece of comparable quality, size and substance.

Candidates will be assessed on AO2 Devising original drama, assessing the candidate's ability to reflect on, analyse and evaluate the devising, rehearsing and performance of their original piece of drama. The questions in Section C will assume that candidates have performed their devised piece to an audience.

Paper 1 – Sections A, B and C

In all sections of Paper 1, candidates' answers should show practical and theoretical understanding of the scripted and devised pieces. The questions will cover a variety of drama skills and techniques related to devising, rehearsing, staging and performing drama, as follows:

- **performing roles** – including use of voice and movement skills, spatial awareness, physicality, pacing and rhythm, interaction with other performers, ways of creating character
- **directing** – including advising actors, developing a directorial concept or interpretation, creating mood and atmosphere, use of space and levels, communicating with the audience
- **designing** – including the contribution of set, props, lighting, sound, costume and make-up to a performance
- **devising** – including use of dialogue and gesture, development of structure, creation of dramatic tension, storytelling (making the narrative clear to the audience), characterisation, use of dramatic contrast and pace, and ensemble.

Candidates should also consider the following aspects of creating drama where appropriate in their answers:

- understanding and interpretation of the extract (Sections A and B only)
- understanding and use of the devising stimulus (Section C only)
- understanding how drama can communicate meaning to an audience
- the resources needed to produce effective drama performance
- the reasons behind the choices they have made and how successful these choices were, or could be, in performance.

Candidates should also know and understand the terms included in the Dramatic and theatrical terms (see section 3 Subject content).

Component 2 – Coursework

Practical work (performance), 120 marks

Component 2 is made up of three compulsory performances. All work must be staged in an appropriate performance space and intended for live performance to an audience.

Practical work	Duration*	Source material
Individual performance	3 minutes maximum	An extract from a published play. The extract is chosen by the teacher and must not be from the pre-release material.
Group performance (2–6 candidates)	3–5 mins per candidate; 20 minutes maximum	An extract from a published play. The extract is chosen by the teacher and must not be from the pre-release material.
Group devised piece (2–6 candidates)	3–5 mins per candidate; 20 minutes maximum	Stimulus chosen by the teacher.

* Each candidate should have broadly equal exposure (performance time) when working in a group. As a guide, each candidate should have 3–5 minutes exposure. We will allow a short overrun from the stated maximum durations when it is required to bring a piece to a clear finish.

Candidates will be assessed **individually** for each performance. Candidates **must** have the opportunity to produce more than three pieces of practical work during the course so that there is a choice of pieces to submit and their best work may be selected. Candidates may select the devised piece submitted for Component 2 as the basis for answering the questions in Section C of Paper 1.

Performances must be recorded for moderation purposes, but the performances produced should **not** be conceived for film or television. The purpose of the video recording is to reproduce the experience of being in the audience for the moderator.

You **must** read the instructions ‘Video recording candidates’ work’ (on page 23) to ensure that you record candidates’ work appropriately.

This component assesses candidates’ abilities in practical work. This includes the ability to interpret published plays, to devise an original piece of drama and to perform effectively to an audience.

Individual and group performance – extracts from a published play

The individual performance requires the candidate to perform an extract from a published play that allows the candidate to demonstrate their abilities within three minutes. There is no stated minimum time, but it is likely that a performance that is significantly shorter than three minutes will be self-penalising. The group performance requires that each candidate has roughly equal exposure of about three to five minutes, depending on the size of the group and the extract being performed. The selection of the extract is important to ensure that each candidate has the opportunity to demonstrate understanding of the style of the drama and the context of their role in the play as a whole.

In both individual and group performances, candidates will be assessed individually on AO1 Knowledge and understanding of repertoire and AO3 Performance skills.

Candidates need to demonstrate their:

- practical understanding of repertoire
- performance skills
- ability to communicate effectively with an audience.

Guidance on selecting play extracts

The extracts for use in the individual and group performances, **must** be chosen by the teacher and be:

- taken from full-length published plays written for the stage (this may include one-act plays)
- chosen according to candidates' abilities and interests
- chosen according to available resources.

You must **not** use television (TV) drama, film screenplays, material taken directly from novels, unpublished works, mini-plays or monologues written specifically for use in the classroom. These will not allow the candidates to demonstrate their understanding or skills appropriately.

Candidates should **not** perform material taken directly from the extracts set as pre-release material for Paper 1. You may choose to perform a **different** scene from the same plays used in the pre-release material. Candidates should **not** perform material taken from the same play for both their individual and group performances.

Group devised piece

The group devised piece must be one that candidates have taken through the devising and rehearsal process. The chosen piece must allow each candidate roughly equal exposure of three to five minutes, depending on the size of the group. The piece must be based on a stimulus chosen by the teacher (see Paper 1 and Component 2 – Guidance on selecting stimuli on page 22). Candidates must decide collectively within their groups on the subject matter, style, characterisation, structure and intention of the piece (with teacher support). Teachers may select the same stimulus or a different stimulus for each group in the class, depending on the abilities and interests of the candidates.

Candidates will be assessed on AO2 Devising original drama and AO3 Performance skills.

They need to demonstrate their:

- ability to devise dramatically effective material from a stimulus
- ability to develop their own role within the piece
- appropriate performance skills
- ability to communicate effectively with an audience.

Use of costume and set in Component 2

Candidates are expected to wear clothes that give an indication of the character they are playing. They are **not** assessed specifically on their use of costume. Candidates' clothes must not conflict with the overall dramatic intention of the character they are seeking to portray, in style, period or fashion. The clothes worn by candidates should be different from their everyday dress unless appropriate to the piece. Candidates are advised not to perform in their school uniforms unless that is appropriate to the role they are playing.

The same principle applies for set, furniture and props. These elements must not undermine, or detract from, the dramatic intention of the piece, but candidates will not be assessed specifically on their use of set design.

Paper 1 and Component 2 – Guidance on selecting stimuli

When answering questions on their devised piece in Paper 1, candidates may choose to write about the same devised piece that they submit for Component 2, or another devised piece of comparable quality, size and substance. **All** devised pieces should be developed using the process described in section 3 Subject content.

Teachers must select the stimulus for each devised piece the candidates develop. They should choose stimuli that enable the candidates to:

- work as a group
- develop strong characters and narratives
- apply the content and skills as described in section 3 Subject content
- analyse and evaluate the devising process and their final performance
- meet the requirements of the assessment objectives.

The best stimuli are likely to be focused and specific rather than abstract.

See 3 Subject content for examples of possible stimuli.

The list is **not** exhaustive and teachers are free to use any material that is appropriate to this level of examination and that enables candidates to devise and perform to the best of their abilities. The stimuli should also be age-appropriate and not offensive in any way.

Although the teacher selects a stimulus for each group, the devised piece must be the original work of the candidates and the group must decide collectively on the subject matter, style, characterisation, structure and intention of the pieces.

Guidance for Component 2 – Coursework

Candidates should undertake coursework with the guidance and ongoing supervision of their teacher. The amount of teacher guidance will vary between individual, group scripted and group devised pieces and the needs of the candidates.

The teacher **must**:

- select appropriate repertoire and stimuli for candidates
- set and/or negotiate coursework tasks
- supervise the work throughout to monitor individual progress
- support, challenge, critique or direct as necessary during the process
- ensure that the work is completed according to the requirements of the syllabus and that it can be assessed in line with the assessment criteria and procedures
- assess the live performance of the work using the assessment criteria on pages 26 to 28 in accordance with the guidance given on page 24.

The teacher **may**:

- challenge candidates on their use of ideas and the crafting of the drama
- act as director for the group performance of the piece of repertoire.

It is recommended that teachers provide time for learners to record their progress, and to evaluate the success of their practical choices and the approaches they have taken.

Video recording candidates' work

The centre must record (make a digital video recording of) all practical work undertaken during the course in order to be able to select each candidate's best work for the final assessment; it is advisable to keep back-up copies of all recordings in case of files being lost or corrupted.

Identifying the candidates

It is essential that the Cambridge International moderator can easily identify the candidates dressed as they will appear in the pieces. At the beginning of each performance, the candidate must identify himself/herself clearly by stating his/her name and candidate number (if known at time of recording). The teacher should also provide notes on the *Individual Candidate Mark Sheet* to help identify the candidate (see 'Submitting candidates' marks and work').

Quality of recordings

It is essential to produce clear recorded evidence. In particular:

- position cameras level with the performance space, and so that the whole action can be clearly seen
- each candidate must be clearly visible and easily identified by the external moderator
- avoid zooming in and out, as this can be distracting
- the camera should be static, not hand-held
- avoid panning to follow performers
- avoid extraneous noise and echo, as this makes it difficult to hear the candidates
- the soundtrack must be clearly audible
- the recording should not be stopped and re-started once the performance has begun.

The centre should re-record any work that does not meet the above standards.

Marking

Each candidate's work must be marked by the teacher according to the assessment criteria provided in this syllabus. Marks are awarded for each candidate as follows:

- AO1 Knowledge and understanding of repertoire – a mark for the **individual** performance and a mark for the **group** performance
- AO2 Devising original drama – a mark for the **group devised** piece
- AO3 Performance skills – a separate mark for **each** of the **three** performances.

Guidance on using levels-based mark schemes

Marking of work should be positive, rewarding achievement where possible, but clearly differentiating across the whole range of marks, where appropriate.

The marker should look at the work and then make a judgement about which level statement is the best fit. In practice, work does not always match one level statement precisely so a judgement may need to be made between two or more level statements.

For each candidate and for each assessment objective, start at the bottom of the grid and work upwards until you reach the level statements that most closely match the quality of the candidate's performance. Use a 'best fit' approach, settling on the level statement that you are confident most fully describes the candidate's performance as a whole. Then check the level statements in the level above to confirm that the candidate has not done enough to be awarded a mark from that level.

Once a best-fit level statement has been identified, use the following guidance to decide on a specific mark:

- If the candidate's work **convincingly** meets the level statements, award the highest mark.
- If the candidate's work **adequately** meets the level statements, award the most appropriate mark in the middle of the range (where middle marks are available).
- If the candidate's work **just** meets the level statements, award the lowest mark.

If you are unsure which mark to award, always choose the **higher** one.

Always assess the live performance of the work rather than the video recording. Make notes during the performance relating to the relevant two assessment objectives for each piece.

To justify the marks that have been awarded, the teacher needs to provide sufficient evidence in the *Individual Candidate Mark Sheet* (see Submitting candidates' marks and work). The comments must be specific and refer to how particular aspects of the candidate's performance meet the assessment criteria.

External moderation

Cambridge International will externally moderate all internally assessed components.

- You must submit the marks of all candidates to Cambridge International.
- You must also submit the marked work of a sample of candidates to Cambridge International.

The sample you submit to Cambridge International should include examples of the marking of each teacher. The samples database at www.cambridgeinternational.org/samples explains how the sample will be selected. The samples database also provides details of how to submit the marks and work.

External moderators will produce a short report for each centre with feedback on your marking and administration of the assessment.

Internal moderation

If more than one teacher in your centre is marking internal assessments, you must make arrangements to moderate or standardise your teachers' marking so that all candidates are assessed to a common standard. (If only one teacher is marking internal assessments, no internal moderation is necessary.) You can find further information on the process of internal moderation on the samples database at **www.cambridgeinternational.org/samples**. The sample of candidate work that is submitted to Cambridge International should include examples of marking from **each** teacher that marks the internal assessment.

You should record the internally moderated marks for all candidates on the *Individual Candidates Mark Sheet* (see Submitting candidates' marks and work) and submit these marks to Cambridge International according to the instructions set out in the *Cambridge Handbook* (**www.cambridgeinternational.org/eoguide**) for the relevant year of assessment.

Submitting candidates' marks and work

Please refer to the samples database at **www.cambridgeinternational.org/samples** for information, dates and methods of submission of candidates' marks and work.

Centres must send the following to Cambridge International with the sample of work for moderation:

- *Individual Candidate Mark Sheet* (0411/ICMS) for all candidates, including those not in the sample; the marks on this form must be the same as the marks you submit to Cambridge International
- *Group devised piece cover sheet*.

All of these forms and the instructions for completing them should be downloaded from **www.cambridgeinternational.org/samples** each year, to make sure you have the most up-to-date instructions. The database will ask you for the syllabus code (i.e. 0411) and your centre number, after which it will take you to the correct forms. Follow the instructions on the form itself when completing each form.

The *Individual Candidate Mark Sheet* (0411/ICMS) is required to provide details of the three performances selected for final assessment and the marks awarded for each. You should enter candidates' marks for Component 2 on this form. Teachers should provide sufficiently detailed comments to support the marks awarded. The marks on this form must be identical to the marks you submit to Cambridge International.

The *Group devised piece cover sheet* is required to provide summary information for the moderator about group composition, roles played and the context/stimulus of the material presented.

Please keep at the centre:

- one complete set of copies of the forms
- all other recorded work.

All records and supporting work should be kept until after the publication of results, and the recordings of all other candidates' work should be kept at the centre. Further samples of work may be requested by Cambridge International.

Assessment criteria for Component 2

Assessment criteria for AO1 Knowledge and understanding of repertoire

This assessment objective applies to the **individual performance** and the **group performance of an extract from a play**. The assessment criteria cover the ability to:

- bring a character to life based on understanding of the role in the play
- interpret this role in a way that demonstrates understanding of the style/genre of the play
- make an informed contribution to the process of moving from script to performance.

Level	Mark	Description
5	13–15	• A perceptive and well-conceived realisation of the character, informed by an in-depth understanding of the role. • An accomplished interpretation of the role, based on an in-depth understanding of the style/genre of the play. • A constructive, problem-solving approach to the process of moving from script to performance.
4	10–12	• An assured realisation of the character, informed by a clear understanding of the role. • An effective interpretation of the role, based on a clear understanding of the style/genre of the play. • A reliable and effective contribution to the process of moving from script to performance.
3	7–9	• A competent realisation of the character, informed by a straightforward understanding of the role. • A believable interpretation of the role, based on a broad understanding of the style/genre of the play. • A competent contribution to the process of moving from script to performance.
2	4–6	• A superficial realisation of the character, informed by a partial understanding of the role. • An uneven interpretation of the role, based on a partial understanding of the style/genre of the play. • An uneven contribution to the process of moving from script to performance.
1	1–3	• An implausible realisation of the character, informed by a limited understanding of the role. • A one-dimensional interpretation of the role, based on a limited understanding of the style/genre of the play. • An ineffective contribution to the process of moving from script to performance.
0		• No creditable response.

Assessment criteria for AO2 Devising original drama

The devised piece assessment criteria cover:

- the quality of the individual role that the candidate has devised within the group piece
- the contribution made by the role to the piece as a whole
- the ability to engage with the devising process in order to create and shape the piece.

Please note that in these criteria the term 'role' is understood to include 'roles' in situations where a candidate performs more than one role within the devised piece.

Level	Mark	Description
5	25–30	• A perceptive and well-crafted role showing some originality. • The role makes an integral contribution to the piece as a whole. • A creative contribution to the process of devising and shaping the piece.
4	19–24	• A well-observed and coherent role. • The role effectively supports the piece as a whole. • A reliable and effective contribution to the process of devising and shaping the piece.
3	13–18	• A competent and recognisable role. • The role generally supports the piece as a whole. • A competent contribution to the process of devising and shaping the piece.
2	7–12	• A superficial role that may rely on stereotype. • The role makes some contribution at key moments in the piece. • An uneven contribution to the process of devising and shaping the piece.
1	1–6	• A patchy, inconsistent or confusing role. • The role makes a peripheral contribution to the piece. • An ineffective contribution to the process of devising and shaping the piece.
0		• No creditable response.

Assessment criteria for AO3 Performance skills

This assessment objective applies to **all three pieces**. The assessment criteria cover:

- the quality of the candidate's performance skills, including but not limited to: vocal articulation, projection, physicality, movement, use of performance space, pace, emotional intensity/truth
- the ability to sustain role(s) throughout the performance
- the extent of the candidate's communication with the audience.

Level	Mark	Description
5	17–20	• An excellent performance that demonstrates consistently effective use of performance skills appropriate to the devised or scripted material. • Portrayal of the role(s) is sustained throughout the performance. • Consistently engaging performance; excellent communication with the audience.
4	13–16	• An assured performance that demonstrates a mostly effective use of performance skills appropriate to the devised or scripted material. • Portrayal of the role(s) is sustained for most of the performance. • An engaging performance; good communication with the audience.
3	9–12	• A competent performance that demonstrates some effective use of performance skills appropriate to the devised or scripted material. • Portrayal of the role(s) is broadly sustained but with some lapses of focus. • A fairly engaging performance; some communication with the audience.
2	5–8	• An uneven performance that demonstrates some use of performance skills appropriate to the devised or scripted material. • Portrayal of the role(s) is evident at some key moments. • A functional performance; little communication with the audience.
1	1–4	• A rudimentary performance that demonstrates limited use of performance skills appropriate to the devised or scripted material. • The portrayal of the role(s) is seldom in focus. • A low level of energy; hardly any communication with the audience.
0		• No creditable response.

Command words

Command words and their meanings help candidates know what is expected from them in the exams. The table below includes command words used in the assessment for this syllabus. The use of the command word will relate to the subject context.

Command word	What it means
Advise	write down a suggested course of action in a given situation
Describe	state the points of a topic / give characteristics and main features
Evaluate	judge or calculate the quality, importance, amount, or value of something
Explain	set out purposes or reasons / make the relationships between things clear / say why and/or how and support with relevant evidence
Explore	write in detail about particular aspects
Identify	name/select/recognise
Outline	set out the main points
Suggest	apply knowledge and understanding to situations where there are a range of valid responses in order to make proposals / put forward considerations

Phrases such as 'How would you ...?', 'What advice would you give?', 'In what ways would you ...?', and 'How effective ...?' may also be seen in the assessment for this syllabus.

5 What else you need to know

This section is an overview of other information you need to know about this syllabus. It will help to share the administrative information with your exams officer so they know when you will need their support. Find more information about our administrative processes at www.cambridgeinternational.org/eoguide

Before you start

Previous study

We recommend that learners starting this course should have studied a broad curriculum such as the Cambridge Lower Secondary programme or equivalent national educational framework.

We do not expect learners starting this course to have previously studied drama.

Guided learning hours

We design Cambridge IGCSE syllabuses to require about 130 guided learning hours for each subject. This is for guidance only. The number of hours a learner needs to achieve the qualification may vary according to each school and the learners' previous experience of the subject.

Availability and timetables

All Cambridge schools are allocated to one of six administrative zones. Each zone has a specific timetable. Find your administrative zone at www.cambridgeinternational.org/adminzone.

You can view the timetable for your administrative zone at www.cambridgeinternational.org/timetables

You can enter candidates in the June and November exam series.

Check you are using the syllabus for the year the candidate is taking the exam.

Private candidates cannot enter for this syllabus. For more information, please refer to the *Cambridge Guide to Making Entries*.

Combining with other syllabuses

Candidates can take this syllabus alongside other Cambridge International syllabuses in a single exam series. The only exceptions are:

- Cambridge IGCSE (9–1) Drama (0994)
- syllabuses with the same title at the same level.

Cambridge IGCSE, Cambridge IGCSE (9–1) and Cambridge O Level syllabuses are at the same level.

Group awards: Cambridge ICE

Cambridge ICE (International Certificate of Education) is a group award for Cambridge IGCSE. It encourages schools to offer a broad and balanced curriculum by recognising the achievements of learners who pass exams in a range of different subjects.

Learn more about Cambridge ICE at www.cambridgeinternational.org/cambridgeice

Making entries

Exams officers are responsible for submitting entries. We encourage them to work closely with you to make sure they enter the right number of candidates for the right combination of syllabus components. Entry option codes and instructions for submitting entries are in the *Cambridge Guide to Making Entries*. Your exams officer has access to this guide.

Estimated entries

Estimated entries may be required for some Cambridge International syllabuses. To find out if estimated entries are required for this syllabus, and for further information about making estimated entries, see the *Cambridge Handbook* for the relevant year of assessment at **www.cambridgeinternational.org/eoguide**

Early examination materials

The pre-release material is made available to centres before the exam. It is also reproduced in the question paper. Candidates must not bring any prepared material into the examination.

Teachers should check the Cambridge website for the relevant year of assessment for information on when and where the pre-release materials will be available. Information on pre-release materials can be found here: **www.cambridgeinternational.org/prerelease**

You may need access to the School Support Hub, our secure online site, which is at **www.cambridgeinternational.org/support**

This site is password protected. Please contact your School Support Hub coordinator for instructions on how to access the School Support Hub.

Exam administration

To keep our exams secure, we produce question papers for different areas of the world, known as administrative zones. We allocate all Cambridge schools to an administrative zone determined by their location. Each zone has a specific timetable.

Some of our syllabuses offer candidates different assessment options. An entry option code is used to identify the components the candidate will take relevant to the administrative zone and the available assessment options.

Support for exams officers

We know how important exams officers are to the successful running of exams. We provide them with the support they need to make entries on time. Your exams officer will find this support, and guidance for all other phases of the Cambridge Exams Cycle, at **www.cambridgeinternational.org/eoguide**

Retakes and carrying forward marks

Candidates can retake the whole qualification as many times as they want to.

Learn more about retake entries, including definitions and information on entry deadlines, at www.cambridgeinternational.org/retakes

Candidates cannot resubmit, in whole or in part, coursework from a previous series for remarking. For information, refer to the *Cambridge Handbook* for the relevant year of assessment at www.cambridgeinternational.org/eoguide

Marks achieved in Component 2 can be carried forward to future series, subject to the requirements set out in the *Cambridge Handbook* for the relevant year of assessment and the *Carry-forward regulations supplement* at www.cambridgeinternational.org/eoguide

To confirm what entry options are available for this syllabus, refer to the *Cambridge Guide to Making Entries* for the relevant series. Regulations for carrying forward component marks can be found in the *Cambridge Handbook* for the relevant year of assessment at www.cambridgeinternational.org/eoguide

Language

This syllabus and the related assessment materials are available in English only.

Accessibility and equality

Syllabus and assessment design

At Cambridge we recognise that our candidates have highly diverse socio-economic, cultural and linguistic backgrounds, and may also have a variety of protected characteristics. Protected characteristics include special educational needs and disability (SEND), religion and belief, and characteristics related to gender and identity.

We follow accessible design principles to make our syllabuses and assessment materials as accessible and inclusive as possible. We review language accessibility, visual resources, question layout and the contexts used in questions. Using this approach means that we give all candidates the fairest possible opportunity to demonstrate their knowledge, skills and understanding.

Access arrangements

Our design principles aim to make sure our assessment materials are accessible for all candidates. To further minimise barriers faced by candidates with SEND, illness or injury, we offer a range of access arrangements and modified papers. This is the principal way in which we comply with our duty to make 'reasonable adjustments', as guided by the UK Equality Act 2010.

Important:

Requested access arrangements should be based on evidence of the candidate's barrier to taking an assessment and should also reflect their normal way of working. For Cambridge to approve an access arrangement, we need to agree that it constitutes a reasonable adjustment and does not affect the security or integrity of the assessment. This is explained in section 1.3 of the *Cambridge Handbook* www.cambridgeinternational.org/eoguide

Applying for access arrangements

- Details of our standard access arrangements and modified question papers are available in section 1.3 of the *Cambridge Handbook* www.cambridgeinternational.org/eoguide
- Centres are expected to check the availability of access arrangements and modified question papers at the start of the course. Check the *Cambridge Handbook*, the assessment objectives listed in the syllabus document and, where applicable, any access arrangement restrictions listed in the syllabus document.
- Contact us at the start of the course to find out if we can approve an access arrangement that is not listed in the *Cambridge Handbook*.
- All applications should be made by the deadlines published in the *Cambridge Handbook*.

After the exam

Grading and reporting

Grades A*, A, B, C, D, E, F or G indicate the standard a candidate achieved at Cambridge IGCSE.

A* is the highest and G is the lowest. 'Ungraded' means that the candidate's performance did not meet the standard required for grade G. 'Ungraded' is reported on the statement of results but not on the certificate.

In specific circumstances your candidates may see one of the following letters on their statement of results:

- Q (PENDING)
- X (NO RESULT).

These letters do not appear on the certificate.

On the statement of results, Cambridge IGCSE is shown as INTERNATIONAL GENERAL CERTIFICATE OF SECONDARY EDUCATION (IGCSE).

On certificates, Cambridge IGCSE is shown as International General Certificate of Secondary Education.

How students and teachers can use the grades

Assessment at Cambridge IGCSE has two purposes:

- 1 to measure learning and achievement
The assessment confirms achievement and performance in relation to the knowledge, understanding and skills specified in the syllabus.
- 2 to show likely future success
The outcomes help predict which students are well prepared for or likely to be successful in a particular course or career.
The outcomes help students choose the most suitable course or career.

Changes to this syllabus for 2028

The syllabus has been updated. This is version 1, published September 2025.

You must read the whole syllabus before planning your teaching programme. We review our syllabuses regularly to make sure they continue to meet the needs of our schools. In updating this syllabus, we have made it easier for teachers and students to understand, keeping the familiar features that teachers and schools value.

There are no significant changes which affect teaching.

Any textbooks endorsed to support the syllabus for examination from 2022 are still suitable for use with this syllabus.



Syllabuses and specimen materials represent the final authority on the content and structure of all of our assessments.

With a Customer Services team available 24 hours a day, 6 days a week, and dedicated regional teams supporting schools in 160 countries, we understand your local context and are here to guide you so you can provide your learners with everything they need to prepare for Cambridge IGCSE.

Quality management

We are committed to providing exceptional quality. In line with this commitment, our quality management system for the provision of international education programmes and qualifications for students aged 5 to 19 is independently certified as meeting the internationally recognised standard, ISO 9001:2015. Learn more at www.cambridgeinternational.org/about-us/our-standards/



School feedback: ‘While studying Cambridge IGCSE and Cambridge International A Levels, students broaden their horizons through a global perspective and develop a lasting passion for learning.’

Feedback from: Zhai Xiaoning, Deputy Principal, The High School Affiliated to Renmin University of China

We are committed to making our documents accessible in accordance with the WCAG 2.1 Standard. We are always looking to improve the accessibility of our documents. If you find any problems or you think we are not meeting accessibility requirements, contact us at **info@cambridgeinternational.org** with the subject heading: Digital accessibility. If you need this document in a different format, contact us and supply your name, email address and requirements and we will respond within 15 working days.

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